The Brain Still Listens to Stories During Surgery Sleep

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When people have surgery, doctors may give them general **anesthesia**. This medicine makes them fully **unconscious**, so they do not feel or remember anything. Scientists thought the brain did little thinking then. A new study suggests it does more.

Researchers at Baylor College of Medicine in Texas studied patients having **epilepsy** surgery. They used tiny tools to record signals from hundreds of brain cells in the **hippocampus**. That part of the brain helps with learning and memory.

First, the scientists played repeating sounds with a different sound mixed in. The brain cells noticed the different sounds and got better at it over time.

Next, they played short stories. The brain activity showed patterns for different kinds of words, like nouns and verbs. It even held clues about which word would come next. "The brain appears to **anticipate** what comes next in a story, even without conscious awareness," said Dr. Sameer Sheth.

Word Treasure

anesthesia -- Medicine that keeps people from feeling pain during surgery.
unconscious -- Not awake and not aware of what is happening.
epilepsy -- A brain condition that can cause seizures.
hippocampus -- A part of the brain that helps with learning and memory.
anticipate -- To guess what will happen next.

Background you need

The brain is made of billions of cells that send tiny electric signals to each other.

During surgery, doctors use medicine so patients sleep deeply and feel no pain.

When we listen to someone talk, our brain often guesses the next word.

Break it down

WHO: Researchers at Baylor College of Medicine, including Dr. Sameer Sheth
WHAT: They found the brain still notices sounds and words under general anesthesia
WHERE: Texas, with patients having epilepsy surgery
WHY: To learn how much the brain can do without being aware

Why it matters

It shows our brains are always busy, even when we are not awake.

Test what you remember

1. Where did the researchers work?

(A) NASA
(B) A school in Ohio
(C) A zoo
(D) Baylor College of Medicine in Texas

2. What does general anesthesia do?

(A) Makes people hungry
(B) Makes people fully unconscious
(C) Makes people run faster
(D) Helps people see

3. Which part of the brain did they study?

(A) The heart
(B) The hippocampus
(C) The eyes
(D) The stomach

4. What did the brain cells do when a different sound played?

(A) They fell asleep
(B) They stopped working
(C) They noticed it
(D) They got louder

5. What did the scientists play after the sounds?

(A) Cartoons
(B) Nothing
(C) Music videos
(D) Short stories

6. Who said the brain appears to anticipate what comes next?

(A) A teacher
(B) A patient
(C) Dr. Sameer Sheth
(D) A nurse

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Dr. Sameer Sheth: Says the brain appears to anticipate what comes next in a story, even without conscious awareness.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):